GLOBAL PRIZE FOR
INNOVATION IN WATER

GPIW 2026 Applicant Guidelines

Transparency, Eligibility & Evaluation

These Guidelines provide an overview of the application, governance, and evaluation framework for the 4th Edition of the Global Prize for Innovation in Water (GPIW). Established by the Saudi Water Authority in partnership with TEHA Group, the GPIW is designed to recognize and support high-potential innovations addressing critical water-sector challenges. This document outlines the key principles, eligibility requirements, prize tracks, assessment process, jury governance, and applicant safeguards that support a fair, consistent, and merit-based award process.

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1. About the Global Prize for Innovation in Water

The **Global Prize for Innovation in Water (GPIW)** is an international initiative established by the **Saudi Water Authority (SWA)** to identify, recognize, and accelerate breakthrough innovations addressing some of the most pressing challenges facing the global water sector.

As growing water demand, climate change, population growth, urbanization, and industrial development place unprecedented pressure on water resources worldwide, the need for innovative, scalable, and sustainable solutions has become increasingly urgent. The Prize was created to support innovators developing technologies, business models, and systemic approaches capable of improving water security, enhancing resource efficiency, strengthening climate resilience, and advancing environmental sustainability across the water value chain.

Since its inception, GPIW has evolved into a global platform connecting researchers, entrepreneurs, technology developers, utilities, industrial players, investors, policymakers, and institutions committed to advancing water innovation. The Prize covers a broad spectrum of challenges, including water production and desalination, water reuse and circular economy solutions, wastewater treatment, digital water management, resource conservation, and sustainable infrastructure.

The growth of the Prize over successive editions reflects the increasing global momentum around water innovation. In 2023, the initiative received 105 applications from 22 countries, representing 85 organizations and resulting in the recognition of seven winning solutions. In 2024, participation expanded significantly, with 540 applications submitted from 56 countries and involving 199 organizations worldwide. The third edition, concluded in 2025, marked a major milestone in the development of the initiative. The Prize attracted 2,570 applications from 119 countries, engaging 316 organizations from across the world and demonstrating the growing importance of international collaboration in addressing water-related challenges. The evaluation process resulted in a shortlist of 36 finalist applications, from which two Grand Prize Winners and twelve Impact Prize Winners were selected. In addition, two Special Mention Recognitions were awarded within a dedicated TRL 8–9 track established to acknowledge mature innovations already demonstrating significant real-world implementation and impact.

Beyond the remarkable growth in participation, the third edition highlighted the diversity and quality of innovations being developed globally. Applications spanned the full innovation spectrum, ranging from early-stage scientific breakthroughs and emerging technologies to advanced solutions approaching commercial deployment and large-scale implementation.

Through the Global Prize for Innovation in Water, the Saudi Water Authority continues to strengthen its role as a global convenor for water innovation, fostering international collaboration and supporting the development of practical, scalable solutions capable of delivering measurable benefits for communities, industries, and ecosystems worldwide.

The fourth edition builds on this foundation by introducing new opportunities for innovators across different stages of technological maturity, further strengthening the international reach, inclusiveness, and impact of the Prize. By bringing together leading innovators and stakeholders from across the global water ecosystem, GPIW continues to contribute to the advancement of innovative solutions capable of supporting a more sustainable, resilient, and water-secure future.

2. Vision, Mission and Impact Goals

The Global Prize for Innovation in Water aims to accelerate the development and adoption of transformative solutions capable of addressing the world's most pressing water challenges and advancing a more sustainable, resilient, and water-secure future.

The Prize is designed to:

- Identify and recognize breakthrough innovations with the potential to generate significant environmental, economic, and societal impact across the global water sector;
- Accelerate the transition of promising technologies and solutions from research, pilot, and demonstration phases to large-scale implementation and market adoption;
- Provide innovators with international visibility and recognition, showcasing leading solutions to a global audience of policymakers, utilities, investors, industry leaders, researchers, and innovation stakeholders;
- Facilitate access to strategic partnerships, investment opportunities, and collaboration networks that can support the growth and deployment of innovative water solutions;
- Promote sustainable water management practices by encouraging technologies and approaches that improve efficiency, reduce resource consumption, enhance circularity, strengthen climate resilience, and support environmental stewardship;
- Support solutions capable of improving water security, increasing access to safe and reliable water services, enhancing sanitation and wastewater management, and protecting critical water resources and ecosystems;
- Foster international collaboration and knowledge exchange among innovators, institutions, industry, academia, and public-sector organizations working to address shared water challenges;
- Encourage the development of scalable, practical, and economically viable solutions capable of delivering measurable and long-term benefits for communities, industries, and ecosystems worldwide;
- Strengthen the role of innovation as a key driver for achieving sustainable development objectives and building resilient water systems for future generations.

3. Award Architecture

To ensure a fair and meaningful comparison between innovations at different stages of maturity, applications are evaluated within three distinct Technology Readiness Tracks.

Track A – TRL 1–3: Research & Proof of Concept

This Track is dedicated to early-stage innovations that have demonstrated a scientific basis or proof of concept but have not yet undergone significant validation in operational environments.

Typical applicants may include:

- Universities and research institutions;
- Academic spin-offs;
- Early-stage startups;
- Research consortia developing novel technologies and methodologies.

The evaluation focuses on scientific merit, originality, transformative potential, and future scalability.

Track B – TRL 4–7: Development & Demonstration

This Track is intended for innovations that have progressed beyond proof of concept and have demonstrated validation through laboratory testing, pilot projects, or operational trials.

Typical applicants may include:

- Growth-stage startups and scaleups;
- Technology providers;
- Utilities and industrial operators;
- Companies preparing for commercial deployment.

The evaluation focuses on technical performance, scalability, implementation readiness, operational feasibility, and market potential.

Track C – TRL 8–9: Special Mentions for Proven Impact and Ecosystem Leadership

This track recognizes mature innovations, enabling initiatives, and ecosystem contributions that have demonstrated measurable impact in real-world water-sector environments.

It is intended for applicants whose work has moved beyond concept development and pilot validation into commercial deployment, operational implementation, market adoption, or significant ecosystem-level influence.

Typical applicants may include: established technology providers, utilities and infrastructure operators, industrial companies, investors, accelerators, innovation hubs, laboratories, public-sector entities, and commercial ventures with demonstrated adoption or measurable sector impact.

The objective of this track is to recognize solutions and initiatives that have successfully translated innovation into tangible outcomes. Evaluation places particular emphasis on demonstrated results, operational performance, scalability, economic value creation, environmental benefits, institutional adoption, and contribution to advancing the water sector.

Applications within Track C compete for dedicated special recognitions celebrating proven technologies, enabling mechanisms, and ecosystem actors that are already delivering measurable benefits for communities, industries, utilities, and the environment.

4. Prize Categories

Track A (TRL 1-3) and Track B (4-7) cover six thematic categories:

a. **Advanced Water Production and Desalination Technologies**: This category recognizes breakthrough technologies that improve the production of potable, industrial, or fit-for-purpose water through desalination, advanced treatment, or alternative water production systems. Examples include new or improved desalination processes, membrane technologies, thermal systems, hybrid treatment trains, advanced materials, energy recovery systems, brine-tolerant processes.

   Submissions should demonstrate how the innovation improves performance compared with existing solutions. Relevant benefits may include lower energy consumption, improved recovery rates, higher water quality, reduced chemical use, lower operational cost, improved membrane durability, reduced fouling, smaller physical footprint, or enhanced suitability for challenging feedwater conditions.

b. **Water Reclamation, Circular Economy and Zero Liquid Discharge (ZLD)**: This category recognizes innovations that enable water, wastewater, brine, and valuable resources to be recovered, reused, recycled, or circulated within municipal, industrial, agricultural, or commercial systems. Examples include water reuse systems, industrial water recycling, brine concentration and valorization, resource recovery technologies, nutrient recovery, mineral extraction from brines,

closed-loop water systems, advanced reuse treatment trains, and Zero Liquid Discharge approaches that minimize liquid waste streams.

Submissions should demonstrate how the innovation reduces freshwater withdrawal, minimizes waste, recovers valuable by-products, improves circularity, or enables water to be reused safely and economically.

c. **Water Efficiency, Conservation and Consumption Management**: This category recognizes technologies, systems, or interventions that reduce water demand, improve water-use efficiency, prevent losses, or optimize consumption across residential, commercial, industrial, and agricultural sectors. Examples include water-saving devices, industrial process optimization, leak detection and reduction, pressure management, demand forecasting, consumption analytics, efficient fixtures, and systems that help users monitor, manage, or reduce water consumption.

   Submissions should demonstrate how the innovation delivers measurable water savings or improves the efficiency of water use compared with existing practices. Relevant indicators may include percentage reduction in consumption, volume of water saved, reduction in losses, cost savings, ease of adoption, reliability, and applicability across different user groups or geographies.

d. **Digitalisation, Automation and Smart Water Management**: This category recognizes digital, automated, and data-driven innovations that improve the monitoring, operation, control, prediction, optimization, or management of water systems. Examples include artificial intelligence, machine learning, IoT sensors, smart metering, digital twins, predictive analytics, autonomous control systems, remote monitoring platforms, decision-support tools, data-driven asset management systems, and software-enabled optimization of treatment plants, distribution networks, wastewater systems, or water resources.

   Submissions should demonstrate that the digital component is central to the innovation, not merely a supporting feature. Relevant benefits may include improved operational efficiency, reduced energy or chemical consumption, faster fault detection, improved asset performance, predictive maintenance, better decision-making, reduced downtime, or enhanced resilience.

e. **Environmental Sustainability and Water Resource Conservation**: This category recognizes innovations that protect, restore, conserve, or improve the long-term sustainability of water resources, aquatic ecosystems, watersheds, groundwater systems, or water-dependent environments. Examples include watershed protection, aquifer recharge, groundwater preservation, pollution reduction, contaminant removal, ecosystem restoration, nature-based solutions, climate adaptation measures, flood and drought resilience tools, sustainable catchment management, and technologies or approaches that reduce harm to freshwater, coastal, or marine environments.

   Submissions should demonstrate how the innovation contributes to measurable environmental protection or resource conservation. Relevant benefits may include improved water quality, reduced pollutant loads, ecosystem restoration outcomes, groundwater preservation, reduced environmental discharge, increased climate resilience, biodiversity benefits, or improved management of vulnerable water resources.

f. **Accessible and Cost-Effective Wastewater Solutions**: This category recognizes wastewater treatment and management solutions that are practical, affordable, scalable, and suitable for improving access to sanitation, treatment, or wastewater reuse across diverse communities and sectors. Examples include decentralized systems, low-cost treatment technologies, modular or containerized systems, low-energy treatment processes, simplified operations and maintenance models, rural or peri-urban sanitation technologies, industrial wastewater treatment solutions, and wastewater reuse systems designed for affordability and ease of deployment.

Submissions should demonstrate how the innovation improves wastewater treatment access, reliability, affordability, operational simplicity, or scalability compared with conventional solutions. Relevant impact indicators may include treatment performance, cost per cubic meter, energy use, maintenance requirements, number of users served, suitability for underserved areas, robustness under local operating conditions, and potential for safe reuse.

Track C (TRL 8-9) covers three categories:

a. **Most Innovative Idea in Water Technology**: This category recognizes an exceptional idea, model, framework, or approach that has made a significant contribution to advancing water technology adoption, deployment, governance, financing, or impact. For this category, "idea" refers to a proven and implemented contribution that has influenced how water technologies are developed, regulated, financed, procured, deployed, scaled, or adopted in real-world settings.

   Applicants should clearly describe what makes the idea exceptional, how it differs from conventional approaches, and how it has contributed to tangible outcomes in the water sector. Evidence may include adoption by public authorities, utilities, industries, or other institutions; measurable improvements in water efficiency or service delivery; increased investment; reduced costs; improved environmental performance; accelerated technology deployment; or replication across different geographies or use cases.

b. **Venture Capital Deal of the Year in Water Tech**: This category recognizes a venture capital deal, investment, financing mechanism, or strategic transaction that has significantly accelerated the development, commercialization, deployment, or scaling of an innovative water technology company or solution.
   Eligible applications may include venture capital investments, corporate investments, project finance structures, blended finance mechanisms, strategic acquisitions, public-private financing models, or other transactions that have enabled meaningful growth in the water technology sector.

   Applicants should describe the technology, company, or platform supported by the deal; why the transaction was significant; and how it enabled growth, validation, deployment, market entry, or scale-up. Strong nominations should show that the deal created value beyond capital provision, such as opening new markets, supporting infrastructure deployment, enabling commercial contracts, strengthening operational capacity, attracting follow-on investment, or helping overcome financing barriers in the water sector.

c. **Most Impactful Lab / Accelerator in Water Tech**: This category recognizes a lab, accelerator, incubator, testbed, research center, innovation platform, or ecosystem-building initiative that has made a significant contribution to developing, validating, commercializing, or scaling water technology innovations.

   Eligible nominations may include programs or organizations that support technology development, pilot testing, applied research, field validation, entrepreneurship, commercialization, investment readiness, utility engagement, industrial partnerships, regulatory navigation, or market adoption of water solutions.

   This category places particular emphasis on ecosystem impact. Applicants should describe the lab or accelerator's distinctive model or approach, the type of innovators or technologies it supports, and the outcomes it has achieved. Strong nominations should demonstrate a clear track record of helping innovators move from research, prototype, or pilot stage toward real-world deployment, commercial traction, or institutional adoption.

5. Awards and Recognition

The GPIW offers a financial prize purse, dedicated recognitions, and selected piloting support to advance the development, validation, and market adoption of high-potential water innovations. Awards are distributed as follows:

- **Grand Prizes - USD 100,000 per winner**: Two winners in total, one winner from Track A (TRL 1-3) and one winner from Track B (TRL 4-7)
- **Impact Medals - USD 50,000 per winner**: Twelve winners in total, six winners from Track A (TRL 1-3) and six winners from Track B (TRL 4-7)
- **Special Mentions - non-monetary recognition**: Up to 6 winners in total under Track C (TRL 8–9), with up to two recognitions in each category.

Post-Award Pilot Development Process

Following the award announcement, **selected winners may be considered for separate piloting support coordinated by the Saudi Water Authority with the Water Technologies Innovation Institute and Research Advancements (WTIIRA)**. Piloting support may be awarded to the two Grand Prize winners and to up to two Impact Medal winners.

Piloting is intended to form part of a broader innovation journey, supporting selected innovations as they progress from a promising technical solution toward validation, demonstrated operational value, and potential future adoption. Through this structured pathway, SWA aims to help selected winners test key assumptions, generate credible performance evidence, refine their solutions under real-world conditions, and assess their potential to deliver measurable value within the water sector.

The pilot development process would include:

- technical due diligence and feasibility assessment;
- identification of a suitable pilot host or test location in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia;
- definition of the pilot objectives, performance measures, and success criteria;
- agreement on the scope of work, responsibilities, budget, timetable, reporting requirements, and required contributions from each party;
- implementation, operation, monitoring, and evaluation of the pilot under a separate agreement;
- review of the pilot results and consideration of possible future deployment, collaboration, or commercial opportunities.

Piloting support of **up to USD 250,000** per selected innovation may be used to support reasonable and agreed costs associated with pilot planning, technical preparation, mobilization, installation, commissioning, operation, monitoring, evaluation, and demobilization. The support is not an unrestricted cash grant and will be provided in accordance with the approved pilot scope, budget, and separate contractual arrangements.

The applicant's required technical, financial, personnel, equipment, or in-kind contribution will be determined for each pilot based on the nature of the technology and the agreed implementation plan. Applicants should not assume that co-funding will be required unless this is specified during pilot development and documented in the separate pilot agreement.

Pilots are expected to take place in Saudi Arabia, providing selected innovators with access to advanced desalination, water reuse, wastewater treatment, and water distribution infrastructure. This enables technologies to be tested under demanding operational conditions and against clearly defined

performance criteria, generating practical evidence that may support further validation, market readiness, and future deployment discussions. The specific pilot location and host facility will be selected based on the technical requirements of the innovation, the availability of suitable operating conditions, and the objectives of the pilot.

Pilot objectives and performance measures will be agreed before implementation. Participation in a pilot, successful completion of a pilot, or achievement of agreed performance targets does not constitute procurement approval and does not guarantee future purchasing, commercial deployment, investment, or wider implementation. Any subsequent opportunity would be subject to separate technical, commercial, legal, regulatory, and procurement processes.

6. Eligibility Requirements and Exclusion conditions

The GPIW is designed to be open, inclusive, and accessible to a broad range of applicants working to advance innovation in the water sector. Applications are welcomed from, among others:

- Early-stage startups and venture-backed scale-ups;
- Multinational corporations and small-to-medium enterprises (SMEs);
- Universities, public or private research institutes, and laboratories;
- Non-Governmental Organizations (NGOs) and civil society groups;
- Public-Private Partnerships (PPPs), municipal water utilities, and utility consortia;
- Individual innovators, research teams, and project teams.

Applicants must ensure that their submission is aligned with at least one Prize track and category and complies with all eligibility requirements set out in these Guidelines.

To preserve the integrity, independence, and impartiality of the Prize, employees, representatives, and members of the GPIW management and delivery teams are not eligible to submit applications. This exclusion includes personnel directly involved in the design, administration, evaluation, governance, or delivery of the Prize within the Saudi Water Authority and The European House – Ambrosetti (TEHA Group).

Members of the Technical Jury, Board Jury, and any other individuals involved in the evaluation or decision-making process are not eligible to submit applications directly. Where a juror has any professional, financial, institutional, personal, advisory, or other material connection with an applicant, applicant organization, submitted project, or nomination, such connection must be promptly and clearly disclosed to the GPIW organizers to allow appropriate conflict-of-interest measures to be applied.

All applications must be submitted in **English** and must contain complete, accurate, and truthful information. Applicants are responsible for ensuring that they possess all necessary rights, permissions, and authorizations related to the submitted innovation, project, initiative, or nomination. Participation in the GPIW must not infringe any third-party rights, including intellectual property rights, confidentiality obligations, contractual restrictions, or applicable laws and regulations.

The GPIW reserves the right to exclude or disqualify any application that is incomplete, misleading, inconsistent with the eligibility requirements, submitted by an ineligible party, or otherwise incompatible with the principles of fairness, transparency, and independence of the Prize.

7. How to Apply

Applications to the GPIW are submitted online through the **official application portal**. The application is organized into **8 sections** and can be completed at your own pace: your progress can be saved as a draft,

allowing you to leave the form and return at any time before the submission deadline. Applications are only considered once formally submitted; saving a draft does not constitute submission.

Before beginning, applicants are encouraged to prepare the required supporting materials and to review the relevant track and category guidance in this document, as the questions presented will vary according to the Technology Readiness Level (TRL) track selected.

The application is structured as follows:

1. **Applicant Information** — Contact details and information about the applicant and their organization.
2. **Innovation Overview** — A high-level description of the innovation, the selected TRL track and prize category, and the water challenge addressed.
3. **Technical Questions** — Questions on the scientific, technical, and developmental basis of the innovation, tailored to the selected TRL track.
4. **Impact & Market** — The scale of the challenge, expected or demonstrated impact, target beneficiaries, competitive landscape, and barriers to adoption.
5. **Team & Organizational Maturity** — Team expertise, intellectual property status, funding history, and development milestones.
6. **Supporting Materials** — Upload of the required documents and video presentation (see below).
7. **Review** — A summary of all responses, which applicants can review and edit before proceeding.
8. **Declaration & Submit** — Confirmation of accuracy and agreement to the Terms and Conditions before final submission.

Supporting materials

As part of Section 6, applicants are asked to provide the following:

- **Pitch Deck or Technical Summary (required):** a document (max 20 slides or equivalent) that presents the innovation, evidence of performance, team, and roadmap. Accepted formats: PDF or PPT, maximum 20 MB.
- **Video Presentation (required):** A short video of 1–2 minutes introducing the innovation and its value. Applicants are encouraged to keep the video concise and focused. Accepted formats: MP4, MOV, or AVI, maximum 50 MB.
- **Supporting Evidence (optional):** Any additional material supporting the application, such as technical reports, pilot results, publications, certifications, or commercial references. Accepted formats: PDF or ZIP, maximum 30 MB.

Key points to note

- All applications must be submitted in **English**.
- Each project, innovation, or nomination may be submitted under **one category only**. Applicants should select the category that best reflects the primary purpose, maturity, and expected or demonstrated impact of the submission. Exact duplicate submissions (i.e. the same project or innovation submitted multiple times under different categories) are not permitted.
- Applicants may submit more than one application where each application relates to a clearly distinct project, innovation, or nomination.
- Applications must be complete and accurate at the time of submission. Incomplete or insufficiently supported applications may be excluded during administrative screening.
- The submission deadline is **September 30, 2026**. Applicants are strongly encouraged to submit ahead of the deadline to avoid last-minute issues.

What happens after submission

Once an application has been formally submitted, applicants will be able to monitor its status through the GPIW application portal, where status updates will be posted. Applicants will be notified by the GPIW team in November whether or not their application has been shortlisted.

Shortlisted applicants may be contacted by the GPIW organizers regarding any required clarifications, additional information, finalist coordination, and award ceremony arrangements. Applicants should ensure that the contact details provided in their application remain accurate and should monitor both their registered email address and the application portal throughout the evaluation period.

8. Application Guidance by TRL Track

A key component of the application is the declaration of the innovation's current Technology Readiness Level (TRL). Applicants must provide a self-assessment of their innovation's maturity and substantiate it through the information and evidence submitted in the application form.

The questions presented in the application form vary according to the Technology Readiness Level (TRL) track selected, reflecting the different levels of maturity, validation, and deployment expected at each stage. This section outlines what applicants are expected to describe within each track so that submissions can be prepared with the appropriate focus and supporting evidence.

Across all tracks and categories, the information provided through the application form will constitute the primary basis for assessment by the Technical Jury and Board Jury. Applicants should therefore ensure that all information is accurate, complete, clearly presented, and supported by appropriate evidence wherever possible.

Track A — TRL 1–3 (Research & Proof of Concept)

Applicants will be asked to describe the core scientific or technological principle underpinning their innovation, including the theoretical, experimental, or conceptual basis of the approach. Submissions should explain what new knowledge, method, or concept the innovation introduces relative to the current state of the art, and what evidence exists to support its validity. Such evidence may include experimental results, simulations, models, laboratory findings, or early proof-of-concept demonstrations. Applicants will also be asked to describe the intended performance improvement or potential impact of the innovation compared with existing solutions, even where such impact remains theoretical or early-stage, and to outline the pathway from the current research stage to a functional prototype or pilot, including key development steps, technical risks, and unresolved scientific or engineering questions.

Track B — TRL 4–7 (Development & Demonstration)

Applicants will be asked to describe the innovation's technical approach and what distinguishes it from existing solutions. Submissions should provide evidence of technical performance to date, including results from laboratory testing, prototype validation, pilot projects, or field deployments, where available. Applicants should include quantitative performance data wherever possible, such as energy consumption, recovery rates, cost per cubic meter, contaminant removal efficiency, reuse potential, or other relevant indicators. Applicants will also be asked whether the innovation has been piloted or deployed; where deployment has not yet occurred, they should explain the current development stage and planned validation activities.

Track C — TRL 8–9 (Special Mentions)

For Track C Special Mention categories, applicants should interpret "innovation" broadly. Depending on the category, the nomination may relate to a deployed technology, an implemented policy or governance

model, an investment transaction, a financing mechanism, a lab, an accelerator, or an ecosystem-building initiative.

Where the application form refers to customers, beneficiaries, market validation, competitors, intellectual property, team capacity, or deployment strategy, Track C applicants should respond in the way most relevant to their nomination. For example, investment-related nominations may refer to the financed company, technology, or platform; lab and accelerator nominations may refer to their portfolio, program model, supported innovators, and ecosystem outcomes; and policy or governance nominations may refer to implementing institutions, affected users, adoption pathways, and measurable sector results.

9. Evaluation Governance and Jury selection

The Global Prize for Innovation in Water (GPIW) is governed through a structured evaluation framework designed to ensure fairness, transparency, consistency, and impartiality throughout the selection process.

The overall administration of the Prize is coordinated by the GPIW Working Group, composed of representatives from the Saudi Water Authority (SWA) and The European House – Ambrosetti Group (TEHA Group). The Working Group is responsible for managing the application process, applicant communications, operational coordination, evaluation logistics, and administrative screening.

As part of this administrative role, the Working Group may review applications to verify completeness, eligibility, category alignment, and compliance with the Prize Guidelines. This may include identifying and excluding applications that are incomplete, ineligible, fraudulent, misleading, submitted by an ineligible party, or otherwise incompatible with the requirements of the Prize. This screening is administrative in nature and does not constitute technical scoring or merit-based evaluation. The Working Group does not participate in the scoring of eligible applications and does not influence the final evaluation results. The merit-based assessment of applications is entrusted to two evaluation bodies: the Technical Jury and the Board Jury.

- The **Technical Jury** consists of internationally recognized experts from academia, research institutions, industry, utilities, and innovation ecosystems. Technical Jurors are responsible for evaluating applications against the official assessment criteria, reviewing the technical merits of each innovation, assessing supporting evidence, and contributing to the development of the shortlist;
- The **Board Jury** consists of senior leaders and internationally recognized figures from across the global water sector, including executives, investors, policymakers, utility leaders, academic leaders, and experts from innovation and sustainability ecosystems. The Board Jury reviews the highest-ranked applications and offers a strategic perspective on their potential impact, scalability, scientific and technical significance, market relevance, implementation potential, and contribution to addressing global water challenges.

To ensure the highest standards of quality and credibility, all jurors are selected through a rigorous appointment process based on clearly defined eligibility criteria. Jurors are appointed on the basis of their expertise, professional experience, international reputation, independence, and demonstrated contribution to the water sector.

In addition to technical or sectoral expertise, jurors are expected to demonstrate strong communication skills, the ability to provide balanced and constructive evaluations, and a commitment to supporting a fair and transparent review process.

All appointed jurors are required to formally accept an Appointment Letter and adhere to a set of mandatory ethical and professional obligations, including:

- A commitment to act in good faith and maintain the highest standards of professional conduct throughout the evaluation process;
- A commitment to evaluate all applications fairly, objectively, and without bias;
- A declaration of any actual, potential, or perceived conflict of interest that could affect their impartiality;
- A commitment to maintain the confidentiality of all applications, evaluation materials, jury discussions, deliberations, and results;
- A commitment not to disclose or use any confidential information obtained through participation in the Prize for personal or professional advantage.

Any juror with an actual, potential, or perceived conflict of interest in relation to a specific application will be excluded from reviewing, scoring, discussing, or influencing the assessment of that application. The GPIW Working Group monitors compliance with these requirements throughout the evaluation process to safeguard the integrity, credibility, and independence of the Prize.

Through this governance structure, GPIW seeks to ensure that all eligible applications are evaluated solely on their merits and that the selection process reflects high standards of excellence, transparency, impartiality, and accountability.

10. Evaluation Process and Winner Selection

The GPIW evaluation process is structured to ensure that all eligible applications are reviewed in a fair, consistent, and evidence-based manner. The process is organized in successive stages, beginning with administrative screening and progressing to independent expert evaluation, shortlisting, and final winner selection.

Track A (TRL 1–3) and Track B (TRL 4–7) are assessed through both Technical Jury and Board Jury evaluations. Track C (TRL 8–9 Special Mentions) is assessed by the Board Jury only, following administrative screening.

a) Stage 1: First Screening

The first stage consists of an administrative screening conducted by the GPIW Working Group. This stage is intended to verify compliance with the Prize Guidelines and does not involve technical scoring or merit-based evaluation.

The administrative screening may include:

- Completeness review: verifying that all mandatory text fields, documentation, and technical attachments are uploaded and readable;
- Eligibility verification: confirming that the applicant is eligible and does not fall under any exclusion conditions;
- Track and category alignment: reviewing whether the application has been submitted under the appropriate track and category based on the information provided;
- TRL consistency check: verifying that the declared Technology Readiness Level is reasonably supported by the evidence submitted;
- Integrity review: identifying applications that may be duplicate, fraudulent, misleading, plagiarized, or otherwise incompatible with the Prize Guidelines.

Applications that do not meet the administrative requirements may be excluded from further consideration. Applications that pass Stage 1 are designated as *compliant submissions* and advance to the relevant evaluation stage.

b) Stage 2: Evaluation and Shortlisting for Track A and Track B

For Track A and Track B, compliant submissions are reviewed by the Technical Jury. Applications are assigned to multiple independent jurors with relevant expertise in the applicable thematic category.

Technical Jurors evaluate applications against the official assessment criteria (see Section 10).

Each application receives Technical Jury scores based on the applicable evaluation criteria. Scores are then consolidated to generate a ranked list within each track.

Based on the Technical Jury assessment, the top-ranked applications are shortlisted for final evaluation:

- Track A Shortlist: top 18 applications from TRL 1–3;
- Track B Shortlist: top 18 applications from TRL 4–7;
- Total Shortlist: 36 applications advanced to Stage 3.

c) Stage 3: Board Jury Evaluation and Final Winner Selection for Track A and Track B

The shortlisted Track A and Track B applications are reviewed by the Board Jury. Final results for Track A and Track B are determined through mathematically weighted averaging model that combines the score of the Technical Jury with the score of the Board Jury. The applications are ranked sequentially by their final combined scores.

The highest-ranked application in Track A and the highest-ranked application in Track B are selected as the Grand Prize winners. Additional top-ranked applications in each track are selected for Impact Medals, in accordance with the award structure of the Prize.

d) Track C: Special Mentions Evaluation

Track C applications, covering TRL 8–9 Special Mention categories, are subject to administrative screening by the GPIW Working Group. Compliant Track C nominations are then evaluated by the Board Jury. Track C categories are assessed independently using criteria appropriate to the nature and objectives of each category. Applications are compared only with other submissions in the same category, rather than across different types of innovation, investment, governance, or ecosystem contribution.

Track C recognitions are non-monetary and are awarded to nominations that demonstrate exceptional contribution, proven implementation, and measurable value for the water sector. Up to two recognitions may be awarded in each Track C category, in accordance with the Prize structure.

Through this staged process, the GPIW seeks to ensure that applications are reviewed consistently, that administrative compliance is separated from merit-based evaluation, and that final winners are selected on the basis of transparent criteria and independent jury assessment.

The evaluation process described above determines the Prize winners and recognitions. Following the award announcement, SWA-WTIIRA may separately assess selected winning innovations for potential piloting support.

Following the conclusion of the evaluation process, applicants may request their evaluation score or other high-level assessment information, where available, by contacting the GPIW team. Individual reviewer comments, comparative rankings, and specific reasons for non-selection may not be provided and are not guaranteed.

11. Assessment Criteria

To ensure total transparency, the evaluation framework assesses applications against eight core criteria. Each assessment criteria carries equal weight in the evaluation process. Applications will be scored against all eight criteria using the applicable evaluation framework for the relevant track.

Evaluation criteria	Assessment dimensions
Technical Excellence	• Strength of the scientific and engineering foundations • Degree of innovation compared with current state of the art • Demonstrated technical performance, validation, or proof of concept • Quality of methodology, design, and implementation approach
Scalability & Feasibility	• Practicality of implementation under real-world conditions • Cost efficiency and affordability at scale • Availability of required infrastructure, resources, skills, and supply chains • Compatibility with relevant governance structures, regulations, standards and permitting requirements
Life-Cycle Impact	• Net environmental impact across the full life cycle • Consideration of energy, carbon, water, materials, waste, and circularity • Broader societal benefits, e.g. health, access, equity, and community acceptance
Durability & Safety	• Long-term reliability, resilience, and maintainability • Ability to operate under variable and harsh real-world conditions • Safety for users, operators, communities, and ecosystems • Identification and mitigation of unintended risks or negative consequences
Clear Market Need	• Relevance to a clearly defined and urgent water-sector problem • Strength of demand from users, utilities, governments, industry, or communities • Degree to which the solution addresses a market gap or systemic failure • Evidence of stakeholder validation (eg. pilots, user feedback, partnerships, etc.)
Performance Measurability	• Clarity of the solution's target outcomes and success metrics • Ability to quantify performance objectively and consistently • Availability of credible testing, monitoring, and verification methods • Transparency of assumptions, data, benchmarks, and claims
Audacious Yet Achievable Vision	• Boldness and originality of the proposed solution

Evaluation criteria	Assessment dimensions
	• Potential to inspire innovation and shift the trajectory of the water sector • Realistic pathway from concept to deployment • Balance between transformative ambition and practical attainability
Long-Term Viability & Execution Capacity	• Strength of the business, implementation, or adoption model beyond the prize, including a credible pathway to sustained deployment. • Potential to attract partners, customers, investors, or public-sector adopters • Capability and credibility of the team to execute, including relevant technical, operational, commercial, regulatory experience • Strength of the intellectual-property, licensing, open-source, partnership, or commercialization strategy supporting long-term adoption, defensibility, and sustainability

12. Timeline

The GPIW follows a structured timeline designed to ensure sufficient time for application submission, review, shortlisting, jury assessment, and final award coordination. The indicative timeline is as follows:

1. **Application Submission Window**: June 4 – September 30.
2. **Administrative Screening and Initial Review**: October 1 – October 10
   Applications are reviewed for completeness, eligibility, track and category alignment, and compliance with the Prize Guidelines.
3. **Technical Evaluation and Shortlisting**: October 10 – October 31
   Eligible applications are assessed by the relevant jury process, and shortlisted applicants are identified.
4. **Shortlist Notification and Finalist Coordination**: November 1 – December 7
   All applicants will be notified of their shortlisting status. Shortlisted applicants will be contacted as needed regarding final-stage requirements, communications, and award ceremony preparations. Application status updates will also be made available through the GPIW application portal.
5. **Board Jury Review and Deliberation**: From November 1
   The Board Jury reviews the relevant shortlisted applications and conducts final deliberations in accordance with the evaluation process.
6. **Winner Announcement and Global Award Ceremony**: December 7
   Final winners and recognitions are expected to be announced during the GPIW Award Ceremony, held as part of the Innovation Driven Water Sustainability (IDWS) Conference, taking place in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, December 7–9, 2026.

13. Confidentiality and Intellectual Property

The GPIW recognizes the importance of protecting applicants' confidential information and intellectual property. All application materials submitted for evaluation will be handled with appropriate care and used

solely for purposes related to the administration, assessment, promotion, and delivery of the Prize, in accordance with these Guidelines and any applicable terms and conditions.

Confidential information may include contact details, technical data, patent-related information, research results, designs, schematics, formulas, business information, commercial metrics, financial information, implementation plans, and other non-public materials submitted as part of an application.

Access to application materials will be limited to individuals and entities with a legitimate role in the Prize process, including the GPIW Working Group, Technical Jurors, Board Jurors, and authorized support personnel. Individuals involved in the evaluation process will be required to comply with confidentiality obligations before accessing non-public application materials.

Applicants are responsible for ensuring that their submissions do not infringe third-party intellectual property rights, confidentiality obligations, contractual restrictions, or applicable laws. Where an application involves intellectual property owned or co-owned by universities, research institutions, companies, partners, employees, funders, or other third parties, the applicant must ensure that all necessary rights, permissions, and authorizations are in place before submission.

All background intellectual property, know-how, data, inventions, designs, software, methods, processes, trade secrets, and other intellectual assets submitted by an applicant remain the property of the applicant or the relevant rights holder. Participation in the GPIW does not transfer, assign, or grant ownership of any intellectual property rights to the GPIW, the Saudi Water Authority, The European House – Ambrosetti, jurors, or any other party involved in the Prize.

The GPIW may publish or communicate non-confidential information about shortlisted applicants, finalists, winners, and recognized nominations for purposes such as public announcements, ceremony materials, reports, media communications, and promotional activities. Such communications will be based on information suitable for public disclosure and should not include confidential technical or commercially sensitive details without appropriate authorization.

Where post-award piloting support is awarded, any intellectual property, data, know-how, improvements, inventions, or other results arising from pilot activities will be addressed in the separate pilot agreement between the relevant parties. That agreement will define ownership, access rights, confidentiality, permitted use, publication rights, and any licensing or commercialization arrangements applicable to the pilot.

14. Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

Q: Is there a fee to apply?

A: No. There is no application fee to submit to the GPIW.

Q: Do applicants choose the prize category, or does GPIW assign it?

A: Applicants are expected to select the track and category that best match the maturity, purpose, and impact of their submission. The GPIW may review track and category alignment during administrative screening and may request clarification or make adjustments where appropriate, in accordance with the Prize Guidelines.

Q: How should applicants choose the correct TRL track?

A: Applicants should select the TRL track that best reflects the current maturity of their innovation. Track A is intended for early-stage innovations at TRL 1–3, including research concepts, laboratory validation, and proof-of-concept work. Track B is intended for innovations at TRL 4–7, including prototypes, pilots, field validation, and pre-commercial deployment. Track C is intended for mature innovations, initiatives, or nominations with demonstrated real-world implementation or market-level impact.

Q: What happens if the declared TRL does not match the evidence provided?

A: Applicants are responsible for self-assessing their TRL and supporting it with appropriate evidence. During administrative screening and evaluation, the declared TRL may be reviewed for consistency with the information submitted. If the selected track is clearly inconsistent with the evidence provided, the application may be reclassified.

Q: Is it possible to apply for more than one category?

A: Each project, innovation, or nomination may be submitted under one category only. Applicants should select the category that best reflects the primary purpose and impact of the submission. The same project or innovation may not be submitted multiple times under different categories. However, applicants may submit more than one application if each application relates to a clearly distinct project, innovation, or nomination.

Q: If an innovation fits multiple categories, how should the applicant choose?

A: Applicants should select the category that best reflects the core function of the innovation. For example, a desalination membrane should normally be submitted under Advanced Water Production and Desalination Technologies, while a digital platform for network optimization should normally be submitted under Digitalisation, Automation and Smart Water Management. Applicants may use the impact-dimension questions in the form to explain additional benefits across other areas.

Q: Can applications be submitted in collaboration with another company or research institution?

A: Yes, it is entirely permissible to submit applications in collaboration with other entities, whether they are research institutions or companies, provided that the applicant has the necessary rights, permissions, and authorizations to submit the innovation. One lead contact (indicated in the application form) should be designated for communication with the GPIW organizers.

Q: Can previously published research be submitted?

A: Yes. Prior publication does not automatically prevent an application from being considered. Applicants should ensure that any submitted research, data, or innovation is presented accurately and that they have the necessary rights to disclose and use the information. Applicants should also clarify the intellectual property status of the innovation where relevant.

Q: Does participation affect ownership of intellectual property?

A: No. Participation in the GPIW does not transfer ownership of the applicant's intellectual property to the GPIW, the Saudi Water Authority, The European House – Ambrosetti, jurors, or any other party involved in the Prize. Applicants retain ownership of their background intellectual property, subject to any pre-existing third-party rights or agreements.

Q: What is the main value of applying under Track A, TRL 1–3?

A: Track A provides an opportunity for early-stage innovators to gain recognition for promising scientific or technological concepts. It is particularly relevant for applicants seeking validation of a novel principle, method, or proof-of-concept with potential to address important water challenges. The Award provides recognition and resources to propel ideas towards further development and eventual market readiness.

Q: What is the main value of applying under Track B, TRL 4–7?

A: Track B is designed for innovations that have moved beyond early research and are progressing toward prototype validation, pilot testing, or pre-commercial deployment. It offers recognition for technologies with stronger evidence of performance and a clearer pathway to real-world application.

Q: What is the purpose of Track C, TRL 8–9 Special Mentions?

Track C recognizes mature innovations, investment activity, policy or governance models, labs, accelerators, and ecosystem-building initiatives that have already demonstrated measurable real-world impact. Track C recognitions are non-monetary.

Q: What do jurors consider during the evaluation process?

A: Jurors assess applications against the official evaluation criteria. Aspects include scientific or technical merit, level of innovation, evidence of performance, feasibility, scalability, environmental and societal impact, cost-effectiveness, market relevance, and contribution to addressing significant water-sector challenges.

Q: Are applications disqualified if information is missing?

A: Applications should be complete and accurate at the time of submission. The GPIW may, at its discretion, request clarifications or additional information where appropriate. However, applications that are incomplete, misleading, fraudulent, ineligible, or insufficiently supported may be excluded from further consideration.

Q: What is the most appealing and significant aspect of participating in GPIW apart of the monetary award?

A: Beyond the attraction of the cash prize, the GPIW initiative is building a strong innovation community that offers participants the invaluable opportunity to gain exposure and expanding network with industry leaders and key players in the water industry. This innovation platform can significantly impact one's career trajectory, fostering connections that may additionally, follow into future collaboration with fellow award winners as well. This collaborative environment fosters synergies, promotes knowledge sharing, and

facilitates the exchange of innovative ideas, ultimately amplifying the potential for transformative impact across the water sector.

Q: Are there restrictions on how monetary awards may be used?

A: Monetary awards are intended to support the continued development, validation, deployment, or scaling of winning innovations. Recipients may use the cash prize at their discretion and are not required to provide proof of expenditure to the GPIW organizers. Winners remain responsible for complying with any legal, tax, reporting, contractual, institutional, or other obligations related to the receipt and use of prize funds.

Q: Is piloting support available for winners?

A: Following the award announcement, selected winners may be considered for separate piloting support coordinated by the Saudi Water Authority with WTIIRA. Support of up to USD 250,000 may be made available for each selected innovation to cover reasonable and agreed pilot-related costs, such as planning, mobilization, installation, operation, monitoring, and evaluation.

Piloting support is not an unrestricted cash grant and is subject to technical feasibility, host-site availability, an agreed scope, budget, timetable, allocation of responsibilities, and execution of a separate pilot agreement. Selection for piloting support is independent of the Prize evaluation and does not guarantee procurement or future commercial deployment.

Q: Is it mandatory to pilot the technology in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, or can the applicant choose where to pilot their technologies?

A: Pilot activities are expected to take place in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, where selected innovations may access advanced desalination, water reuse, wastewater treatment, and distribution infrastructure and be tested under demanding operational conditions. The specific host site will be identified by SWA-WTIIRA based on the requirements of the technology and the availability of suitable operating conditions.

Any pilot activity will be subject to separate discussions and agreements with each winner. These arrangements will be tailored to the specific technology, project objectives, implementation requirements, and potential impact of the innovation.

Q: Where and when will the award ceremony take place?

A: The GPIW Award Ceremony is expected to take place on December 7, 2026, as part of the program of the Innovation Driven Water Sustainability (IDWS) Conference, taking place in Jeddah, Saudi Arabia, from December 7–9, 2026. Final logistical details will be communicated by the GPIW organizers to shortlisted applicants and relevant participants.

Q: Is attendance at the award ceremony mandatory?

A: Shortlisted finalists and Special Mention winners will be invited to attend the GPIW Award Ceremony and IDWS Conference. Attendance is strongly encouraged in order to ensure appropriate recognition and visibility of the selected applications; however, if the original applicant or project lead is unable to attend,

the applicant may designate one representative to attend on their behalf. Further attendance instructions will be communicated by the GPIW organizers.

Q: Is the Award ceremony an open event or does it require an invitation?

A: The GPIW Award Ceremony is open to registered participants of the Innovation Driven Water Sustainability (IDWS) Conference. Shortlisted finalists and Special Mention winners will receive dedicated invitations from the GPIW organizers. Other applicants and interested stakeholders may also attend by registering for the IDWS Conference through the official registration link. Attendance remains subject to registration requirements, venue capacity, and any event access rules communicated by the organizers.

Q: Will travel and accommodation be covered for finalists or winners?

A: For invited shortlisted finalists and Special Mention winners, the GPIW will cover the participation costs of one representative per application, in accordance with the travel and logistics arrangements communicated by the organizers. Applicants may request or arrange for additional team members or representatives to attend, subject to event capacity; however, any costs related to additional attendees will not be covered by the GPIW.